

a Never Too Matcha Product field guide

Prototyping with AI

A short, practical crash course for product people who want to go from idea to clickable prototype in an afternoon, not a sprint.

This isn't a prompt-engineering course. It's a framework for getting the idea out of your head and onto the screen, so people can react to what you actually mean.

06

lessons

~20

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01

worksheet

1 Stop writing specs. Start whisking prototypes.

Most of us in product came up trained to describe things before they exist: user stories, wireframe callouts, acceptance criteria. AI prototyping flips that order. You can show the thing before you've finished describing it, and let the description catch up afterward.

That changes what your first move should be. Instead of opening a doc, a

PPT, or whatever your requirement-writing tool of choice is, open a prompt. A rough, unpolished, clickable version of an idea will teach you more in ten minutes than a well-written spec will in two days, because people, including you, react to things far more honestly than they react to bullet points.

Throughout my career, most of the real problems in product development have come back to the same root cause: assumptions. I'd be sure people understood what I meant, and they'd be sure too, right up until we got into the detail and had to put it into each other's words — and that's when the gaps showed up. Prototyping earlier changes that. When the experience sits in front of stakeholders instead of being described to them, it strips out most of those assumptions before they ever get the chance to take hold. People react to what's actually there, and they build with you in real time, instead of only meeting the experience much later in the product development lifecycle.

The mindset shift

A prototype's job is to be wrong quickly, in public, where you can see it. Treat the first version as disposable — its only purpose is to surface the next question.

2 Pick a lane, not a tool

The tool landscape moves fast, so it's worth anchoring on categories rather than any one product name. Here's roughly who's playing in each lane right now:

Conversational builders

Chat-based assistants that generate and iterate on interfaces through back-and-forth prompting. Best when your idea is still fuzzy and you want to think out loud.

C Claude

G ChatGPT

S Google Stitch

Purpose-built app generators

Tools that turn a written brief into a working app scaffold in one pass. Best once you already know roughly what screens and flows you need.

L Lovable

B Bolt.new

R Replit

Design-to-code tools

Tools that convert a sketch, screenshot, or existing design file into front-end code. Best when the visual direction already exists and you need it wired up fast.

V v0 by Vercel

F Figma Make

U Uizard

This list will look different in six months — that's just where the category is right now. Treat it as a starting point for exploring, not a final answer.

Match the lane to the stage your idea is at, not the other way around. Don't reach for a full app generator when you're still working out what the product even is.

3 The core loop: describe, generate, critique, refine

Every good AI prototyping session runs on the same four-beat loop, over and over:

1. **Describe** — say what you want in plain language, anchored to a real user and a real moment, not a feature list.
2. **Generate** — let the tool produce a first pass. Resist the urge to over-specify before you've even seen anything.
3. **Critique** — react like a user, not an engineer. What's confusing? What's missing? What caught you off guard?
4. **Refine** — feed that critique back in as one targeted change at a time, not a wish list.

Ten short loops beat one long one, every time. If you find yourself writing paragraphs of instruction before you've seen a single output, you've slipped back into writing a spec.

4 Prompting like a PM, not like a spec sheet

A strong prototyping prompt reads like a tight product brief, not a requirements document. Four things belong in almost every one:

- **Who** it's for, in one line.
- **What moment** in their day this shows up in.
- **What "done" looks like** — the one thing the prototype has to let someone do.
- **What to leave out** — scope is as useful going in as it is coming out.

Example prompt

"Build a simple screen for a commuter checking whether their train is delayed before they leave the house. It should show the next departure and a clear delayed/on-time state at a glance. Don't build login, settings, or notifications yet — just this one screen."

Notice what's missing: no colour codes, no component names, no

engineering language. That's deliberate at this stage. Let the tool make the craft decisions, and spend your specificity on the problem, not the pixels.

5 **Get it in front of someone before you polish it**

A prototype's value decays the longer it sits unshown. The moment it does the one thing you set out to test, stop refining and get it in front of a real person — a colleague, a user, even someone outside your target audience who'll react honestly.

Watch what they do, not just what they say. Where do they hesitate? What do they tap first? Those reactions are worth more than a week of internal debate about what the "right" flow should be.

A useful rule of thumb

If nobody outside your team has seen the prototype yet, it isn't done being rough — it's just done being shown to you.

6 **Traps worth knowing before you fall into them**

Polish is not validation

A clean, well-animated prototype can feel "finished" long before the idea underneath it has actually been tested. Don't mistake how good it looks for how sound it is.

Scope creep by suggestion

AI tools are generous — they'll happily add settings pages, edge cases, and extra screens you never asked for. Every unrequested addition is

scope you now have to evaluate. Prune it back hard.

Ownership and reuse

Know your organisation's and the tool's policies on what happens to prompts, outputs, and any real data before you paste real user information or proprietary content into a prototyping tool.

A note from the field

I used to rely on PowerPoint to get ideas across, and it did the job – it got a concept in front of people and started the conversation. But it was still a picture of an idea, not the idea itself. Prototyping with AI has changed the pace of discovery more than anything else I've picked up in the last few years. What used to take weeks of workshops and back-and-forth documentation now surfaces in days: a working version of an idea puts flaws in the customer experience flow in front of you almost immediately, rather than three sprints later.

It's also the fastest way I've found to spot hidden complexity early – the edge cases and dependencies that never show up in a user story but show up the moment something is clickable. Catching that early let me build a roadmap that was genuinely iterative, so I could ship value sooner and keep refining as the team learned more, rather than waiting for a "finished" spec before anything shipped at all.

Being able to build something interactive without writing a line of code has been genuinely liberating. The gap between having an idea and being able to show it to someone has never been this small.

Gabriel Carlos · Senior Manager, Product Development

Your first loop — try it this week

- ☐ Pick one real moment in a user's day. Write it down in one sentence.
- ☐ Write a prompt with who, moment, done, and what to leave out.
- ☐ Generate a first pass. Don't touch it yet — just react to it.
- ☐ Write down the single most confusing thing about it.
- ☐ Feed that one thing back in as your only instruction.
- ☐ Show it to one person who hasn't seen it yet.

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